

Sweat

Zora Neale Hurston · 1926

First published: Fire!!, Nov 1926

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Fire!!/Sweat (revision 12141461), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 11–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Sweat suggest about endurance and justice?
- What does Sweat suggest about domestic abuse?
- What does Sweat suggest about faith?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: Common Core

RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one

essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.

Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* Sweat	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*endurance and justice* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to Sweat

Author biography

Zora Neale Hurston was born in Notasulga, Alabama, on 7 January 1891 and grew up in Eatonville, Florida, one of the first incorporated all-Black towns in the United States. She studied at Howard University and at Barnard College under the anthropologist Franz Boas, collected African American folklore in the South and the Caribbean (Mules and Men, 1935), and became a central figure of the Harlem Renaissance. Their Eyes Were Watching God (1937) is her best-known story. She died in poverty in Fort Pierce, Florida, on 28 January 1960; Alice Walker's 1975 essay "In Search of Zora Neale Hurston" led to her rediscovery.

Historical and cultural context

Set in a Florida town in the 1920s; Black washerwomen did white families' laundry.

Publication and reception, then and now

Published in Fire!! (1926), a Harlem Renaissance magazine.

Then: Fire!! had limited circulation.

Now: A classic of Hurston's dialect fiction, domestic violence and justice.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Delia, a washerwoman, has supported her abusive husband Sykes for fifteen years; he tries to drive her out.

Main themes

- oppression and resilience.
- justice.
- work and dignity.

Why it matters

The story discusses domestic violence and moral choice.

Spoilers · teacher only

Sykes puts a rattlesnake in the house to kill her; it bites him, and Delia does not save him.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open Sweat: When is it right to refuse help?
Prompt: Before we open Sweat: When is it right to refuse help?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

dialect; symbol; irony; foreshadowing.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Zora Neale Hurston was born in Notasulga, Alabama, on 7 January 1891 and grew up in Eatonville, Florida, one of the first incorporated all-Black towns in the United States. She studied at Howard University and at Barnard College under the anthropologist Franz Boas, collected African American folklore in the South and the Caribbean (Mules and Men, 1935), and became a central figure of the Harlem Renaissance. Their Eyes Were Watching God (1937) is her best-known story. She died in poverty in Fort Pierce, Florida, on 28 January 1960; Alice Walker's 1975 essay "In Search of Zora Neale Hurston" led to her rediscovery. The world of the book. Set in a Florida town in the 1920s; Black washerwomen did white families' laundry. Publication and reception. Published in Fire!! (1926), a Harlem Renaissance magazine. Then: Fire!! had limited circulation. Now: A classic of Hurston's dialect fiction, domestic violence and justice.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"Sweat, sweat, sweat! Work and sweat, cry and sweat, pray and sweat" (Sweat, paragraph 18). Delia's labor.

> *Sweat, sweat, sweat! Work and sweat, cry and sweat, pray and sweat* (Sweat, paragraph 18)

Think-aloud: "Sweat, sweat, sweat! Work and sweat, cry and sweat, pray and sweat" (Sweat, paragraph 18). Delia's labor.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Delia, a washerwoman, has supported her abusive husband Sykes for fifteen years; he tries to drive her out. Themes to track: oppression and resilience.: justice.: work and dignity.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for Sweat: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does Sweat still matter? The story discusses domestic violence and moral choice.
Anchor question: Why might Sweat still be taught today?
Facilitation: The story discusses domestic violence and moral choice.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Was Delia right not to help Sykes? Answer: Students should argue; the story presents it as just.
Exit ticket: Was Delia right not to help Sykes?
Answer: Students should argue; the story presents it as just.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: Sweat.

Teacher notes · sources: Zora Neale Hurston Trust, "About Zora" (https://www.zoranealehurston.com/about/); Britannica, "Zora Neale Hurston" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Zora-Neale-Hurston); Zora Neale Hurston Trust (https://www.zoranealehurston.com/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Content note: domestic violence.

Lesson 2: Sweat

Focus: endurance turning to justice

Objective: Students will analyze how symbolism develops in "Sweat" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: CCSS RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4 · IN 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.11

Content note (domestic abuse, racial slurs in dialogue, snakebite death): Sensitive content: Domestic abuse; racial slurs in dialogue; snakebite death. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. The text quotes racial slurs in period dialogue: decide in advance that no one reads them aloud, and name why the author records them.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes domestic abuse; racial slurs in dialogue; snakebite death.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Delia Jones, a washerwoman in Eatonville, Florida, has supported her abusive husband Sykes for fifteen years. Sykes wants her out of the house for his mistress and terrorizes her with a rattlesnake he keeps in a box. One night the snake gets loose; Sykes, in the dark, is bitten. Delia, hearing his cries, does not help, and waits under the Chinaberry tree as he dies.

Background: Published in 1926 in Fire!!, the one-issue Harlem Renaissance magazine edited by Wallace Thurman. Its US copyright term has expired (1926 publication).

Significance: A central Harlem Renaissance story that uses Eatonville dialect and biblical symbolism.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is there a point where it is right to stop helping someone who has hurt you? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to justice because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes domestic abuse; racial slurs in dialogue; snakebite death.
Prompt: Is there a point where it is right to stop helping someone who has hurt you?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to justice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
*Today's words: retrospection — looking back on the past; penniless — not having enough money to pay for necessities; subscribed — offer to buy, as of stocks and shares; collapsed — break down, literally or metaphorically; chewing — chew (food); to bite and grind with the teeth. "penniless": From Middle English penyles, penylees; equivalent to penny + less. Compare Old Norse penningalauss "penniless". "collapsed": From Latin collāpsus (past participle of collābor). "chewing": From Middle English chewynge, chewand, from Old English *ċēowende, from Proto-Germanic *kewwandz, present participle of Proto-Germanic *kewwaną "to chew", equivalent to chew + -ing.*
Words: retrospection: looking back on the past · penniless: not having enough money to pay for necessities · subscribed: offer to buy, as of stocks and shares · collapsed: break down, literally or metaphorically · chewing: chew (food); to bite and grind with the teeth

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in 1926 in Fire!!, the one-issue Harlem Renaissance magazine edited by Wallace Thurman. Its US copyright term has expired (1926 publication). A central Harlem Renaissance story that uses Eatonville dialect and biblical symbolism. Irony: Sykes brings the rattlesnake to kill Delia, who fears snakes, and it kills him instead; his weapon recoils on him. Symbolism: The snake (and the bullwhip Sykes throws on her, which "looks just like a snake") stands for Sykes's cruelty and, biblically, for evil in the home. Dialect: Characters speak rural Black Florida dialect, which Hurston presents with respect; the porch men offer a chorus that condemns Sykes. Watch for sweat: Delia's labor, which pays for the house she claims as her own.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it" (Sweat, paragraph 20). Delia's claim. That is irony at work: Sykes brings the rattlesnake to kill Delia, who fears snakes, and it kills him instead; his weapon recoils on him.

> *Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it (Sweat, paragraph 20)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it" (Sweat, paragraph 20). Delia's claim. That is irony at work: Sykes brings the rattlesnake to kill Delia, who fears snakes, and it kills him instead; his weapon recoils on him.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The repetition of "sweat" with work, cry and pray shows fifteen years of physical and emotional exhaustion and grounds her claim to the house. Ask: How does this line connect to justice? Expected: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. (Delia.)

> *Sweat, sweat, sweat! Work and sweat, cry and sweat, pray and sweat* (Sweat, paragraph 18)

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The repetition of "sweat" with work, cry and pray shows fifteen years of physical and emotional exhaustion and grounds her claim to the house.
Ask: How does this line connect to justice?
Expected answer: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. (Delia.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for irony, symbolism (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about endurance turning to justice? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Sweat develops the idea of endurance turning to justice. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. When the text says “Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it” (Sweat, paragraph 20), it shows this directly. She tells him "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it," and sums up fifteen years as "Sweat, sweat, sweat!"; when Sykes's own snake kills him, the story lets her keep what she earned.
Task: Annotate the story for irony, symbolism (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about endurance turning to justice? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Sweat develops the idea of endurance turning to justice. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. When the text says “Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it” (Sweat, paragraph 20), it shows this directly. She tells him "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it," and sums up fifteen years as "Sweat, sweat, sweat!"; when Sykes's own snake kills him, the story lets her keep what she earned.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is there a point where it is right to stop helping someone who has hurt you? Ask: was Delia right to wait under the Chinaberry tree? Distinguish justice, revenge and survival. Teacher care: domestic violence; share support resources.
Anchor question: Is there a point where it is right to stop helping someone who has hurt you?
Facilitation: Ask: was Delia right to wait under the Chinaberry tree? Distinguish justice, revenge and survival. Teacher care: domestic violence; share support resources.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about endurance turning to justice? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. ("Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it", Sweat, paragraph 20). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about endurance turning to justice? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. ("Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it", Sweat, paragraph 20). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how irony shapes endurance turning to justice. Key takeaway: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Irony:** Sykes brings the rattlesnake to kill Delia, who fears snakes, and it kills him instead; his weapon recoils on him.
- **Symbolism:** The snake (and the bullwhip Sykes throws on her, which "looks just like a snake") stands for Sykes's cruelty and, biblically, for evil in the home.
- **Dialect:** Characters speak rural Black Florida dialect, which Hurston presents with respect; the porch men offer a chorus that condemns Sykes.

Themes and how they develop

- **justice:** Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival.

Symbols and motifs

- **sweat:** Delia's labor, which pays for the house she claims as her own.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Sweat, sweat, sweat! Work and sweat, cry and sweat, pray and sweat" (Sweat, paragraph 18) Delia.
- "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it" (Sweat, paragraph 20) Delia's claim.
- "It was eleven o'clock of a Spring night in Florida" (Sweat, paragraph 1) The opening.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take.
Evidence: "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it" (Sweat, paragraph 20)
Reasoning: She tells him "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it," and sums up fifteen years as "Sweat, sweat, sweat!"; when Sykes's own snake kills him, the story lets her keep what she earned.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
retrospection (noun)	looking back on the past	*A period of introspection, a space of retrospection, then a mixture of both.*	
penniless (adjective)	not having enough money to pay for necessities	*She had the memory of his numerous trips to Orlando with all of his wages when he had returned to her penniless, even before the first year had passed.*	"penniless": From Middle English penyles, penylees; equivalent to penny + less. Compare Old Norse penningalauss "penniless". (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/penniless#Etymology)
subscribed (verb)	offer to buy, as of stocks and shares	*The money was quickly subscribed and the huge melon brought forth.*	
collapsed (verb)	break down, literally or metaphorically	*Even conversation had collapsed under the heat.*	"collapsed": From Latin collāpsus (past participle of collābor). (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/collapse#Etymology)
chewing (verb)	chew (food); to bite and grind with the teeth	*Sykes almost let the huge wad of corn bread and collard greens he was chewing fall out of his mouth in amazement.*	"chewing": From Middle English chewynge, chewand, from Old English *ċēowende, from Proto-Germanic *kewwandz, present participle of Proto-Germanic *kewwaną "to chew", equivalent to chew + -ing. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/chewing#Etymology)

crouched (verb)	bend one's back forward from the waist on down	*Delia descended without fear now, and crouched beneath the low bedroom window.*	
stumbling (verb)	walk unsteadily	*She nearly fell upon the box in her stumbling, and when she saw what it held, she all but fainted outright.*	
subsided (verb)	wear off or die down	*The shade torn violently down from the window, letting in the red dawn, a huge brown hand seizing the window stick, great dull blows upon the wooden floor punctuating the gibberish of sound long after the rattle of the snake had abruptly subsided.*	“subsided”: From Latin subsīdō "to settle, subside". (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/subside#Etymology)
chooses (verb)	pick out, select, or choose from a number of alternatives	*Ah chooses dat long, bowlegged Floridy favorite."*	
struggles (noun)	an energetic attempt to achieve something	*She went on into the house with a new hope in its birth struggles.*	

Discussion questions

1. Is there a point where it is right to stop helping someone who has hurt you?
2. Where does symbolism appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with endurance and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What is Delia's work? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Washing white people's clothes
2. What does Sykes use to frighten Delia? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A rattlesnake

3. Whom does Sykes want in the house instead? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: His mistress, Bertha
4. Who is bitten by the snake? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Sykes
5. Where does Delia wait at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Under the Chinaberry tree
6. Retell the three most important events of "Sweat" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Delia Jones, a washerwoman in Eatonville, Florida, has supported her abusive husband Sykes for fifteen years. Sykes wants her out of the house for his mistress and terrorizes her with a rattlesnake he keeps in a box. One night the snake gets loose; Sykes, in the dark, is bitten. Delia, hearing his cries, does not help, and waits under the Chinaberry tree as he dies.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "Sweat"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "Sweat" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "A period of introspection, a space of retrospection, then a mixture of both." What does "retrospection" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: retrospection: looking back on the past.
10. Reread: "She had the memory of his numerous trips to Orlando with all of his wages when he had returned to her penniless, even before the first year had passed." What does "penniless" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: penniless: not having enough money to pay for necessities.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "Sweat" suggest about endurance turning to justice? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A central Harlem Renaissance story that uses Eatonville dialect and biblical symbolism.
2. Find one example of symbolism in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
3. How does the characterization in this story shape what we understand about endurance turning to justice? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: "Sweat, sweat, sweat! Work and sweat, cry and sweat, pray and sweat" (Sweat, paragraph 18): Delia. Theme link: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins "It was a hot, hot day near the end of July.", why might Hurston have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in "Sweat", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Delia Jones, a washerwoman in Eatonville, Florida, has supported

her abusive husband Sykes for fifteen years. Sykes wants her out of the house for his mistress and terrorizes her with a rattlesnake he keeps in a box. One night the snake gets loose; Sykes, in the dark, is bitten. Delia, hearing his…

6. As the opening story, what does "Sweat" set up that the rest of Sweat will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it" (Sweat, paragraph 20): Delia's claim. Theme link: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: "It was eleven o'clock of a Spring night in Florida" (Sweat, paragraph 1): The opening. Theme link: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: "Is there a point where it is right to stop helping someone who has hurt you?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does diction / vocabulary appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with endurance and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: "Sweat, sweat, sweat! Work and sweat, cry and sweat, pray and sweat" (Sweat, paragraph 18): Delia. Theme link: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in 1926 in Fire!!, the one-issue Harlem Renaissance magazine edited by Wallace Thurman. Its US copyright term has expired (1926 publication). How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it" (Sweat, paragraph 20): Delia's claim. Theme link: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "A central Harlem Renaissance story that uses Eatonville dialect and biblical symbolism." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that

Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: “It was eleven o'clock of a Spring night in Florida” (Sweat, paragraph 1): The opening. Theme link: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: “Sweat, sweat, sweat! Work and sweat, cry and sweat, pray and sweat” (Sweat, paragraph 18): Delia. Theme link: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “Sweat” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about endurance turning to justice? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: “Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it” (Sweat, paragraph 20): Delia's claim. Theme link: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “Sweat”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: “It was eleven o'clock of a Spring night in Florida” (Sweat, paragraph 1): The opening. Theme link: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to domestic abuse: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Hurston need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: “Sweat, sweat, sweat! Work and sweat, cry and sweat, pray and sweat” (Sweat, paragraph 18): Delia. Theme link: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Is the symbolism in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: “Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it” (Sweat, paragraph 20): Delia's claim. On symbolism: The snake (and the bullwhip Sykes throws on her, which "looks just like a snake") stands for Sykes's cruelty and, biblically, for evil in the

home. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “Sweat” treats endurance turning to justice with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Sweat see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: “It was eleven o'clock of a Spring night in Florida” (Sweat, paragraph 1): The opening. Theme link: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve endurance and justice? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: “Sweat, sweat, sweat! Work and sweat, cry and sweat, pray and sweat” (Sweat, paragraph 18): Delia. Theme link: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about endurance turning to justice? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: “Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it” (Sweat, paragraph 20): Delia's claim. Theme link: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Zora Neale Hurston about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Useful evidence: “It was eleven o'clock of a Spring night in Florida” (Sweat, paragraph 1): The opening. Theme link: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Symbolism:** look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Sykes use to frighten Delia?

   A. A whip

   B. A gun

   C. A dog

   D. A rattlesnake

   Key: D (A rattlesnake)

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whom does Sykes want in the house instead?

   A. His mother

   B. His brother

   C. No one

   D. His mistress, Bertha

   Key: D (His mistress, Bertha)

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Sykes almost let the huge wad of corn bread and collard greens he was _____ fall out of his mouth in amazement." Word bank: subscribed, retrospection, penniless, chewing

   Key: chewing

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Sweat, paragraph 20: "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with _____ more times than yo' hands is filled it"

   Key: vittles

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "The shade torn violently down from the window, letting in the red dawn, a huge brown hand seizing the window stick, great dull blows upon the wooden floor punctuating the gibberish of sound long after the rattle of the snake had abruptly _____."

   Word bank: subscribed, subsided, retrospection, penniless

   Key: subsided

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Delia's work?

   A. Farming

   B. Teaching

   C. Washing white people's clothes

   D. Cooking in a hotel

   Key: C (Washing white people's clothes)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is bitten by the snake?

   A. Sykes

   B. A neighbor

   C. Bertha

   D. Delia

   Key: A (Sykes)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where does Delia wait at the end?

   A. In the barn

   B. Under the Chinaberry tree

C. In the church

D. At a neighbor's

Key: B (Under the Chinaberry tree)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Sweat, paragraph 1: “It was eleven o'clock of a Spring night in _____”

   Key: Florida

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Delia descended without fear now, and _____ beneath the low bedroom window.” Word bank: retrospection, penniless, crouched, subscribed

    Key: crouched

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Sweat, sweat, sweat! Work and sweat, cry and sweat, pray and sweat” (Sweat, paragraph 18) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Delia.

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Sweat”?

    A. Superstition used against a credulous man

    B. Courage in defense of home

    C. Racial pride destroying love

    D. Endurance turning to justice

    Key: D (Endurance turning to justice)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it” (Sweat, paragraph 20) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Delia's claim.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Sweat”? The snake (and the bullwhip Sykes throws on her, which "looks just like a snake") stands for Sykes's cruelty and, biblically, for evil in the home.

    A. Personification

    B. Conflict

    C. Symbolism

    D. Hyperbole

    Key: C (Symbolism)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Sweat”? Sykes brings the rattlesnake to kill Delia, who fears snakes, and it kills him instead; his weapon recoils on him.

    A. Irony

    B. Conflict

    C. Hyperbole

    D. Foreshadowing

    Key: A (Irony)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

Sample answer: She tells him "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it," and sums up fifteen years as "Sweat, sweat, sweat!"; when Sykes's own snake kills him, the story lets her keep what she earned.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “She nearly fell upon the box in her _____, and when she saw what it held, she all but fainted outright.” Word bank: subscribed, penniless, stumbling, retrospection

    Key: stumbling

18. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “It was eleven o'clock of a Spring night in Florida” (Sweat, paragraph 1). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The opening.

19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it” (Sweat, paragraph 20).

    Sample answer: She tells him "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it," and sums up fifteen years as "Sweat, sweat, sweat!"; when Sykes's own snake kills him, the story lets her keep what she earned.

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it” (Sweat, paragraph 20) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Delia's claim.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how justice develops from an earlier story to “Sweat”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Sweat, sweat, sweat! Work and sweat, cry and sweat, pray and sweat” (Sweat, paragraph 18) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Delia.

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Even conversation had collapsed under the heat.”, what does “collapsed” most nearly mean?

    A. not having enough money to pay for necessities
    B. break down, literally or metaphorically
    C. looking back on the past
    D. offer to buy, as of stocks and shares

    Key: B (break down, literally or metaphorically)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “A period of introspection, a space of retrospection, then a mixture of both.”, what does “retrospection” most nearly mean?

    A. not having enough money to pay for necessities
    B. looking back on the past
    C. break down, literally or metaphorically
    D. offer to buy, as of stocks and shares

    Key: B (looking back on the past)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "She had the memory of his numerous trips to Orlando with all of his wages when he had returned to her penniless, even before the first year had passed.", what does "penniless" most nearly mean?

    A. break down, literally or metaphorically

    B. offer to buy, as of stocks and shares

    C. looking back on the past

    D. not having enough money to pay for necessities

    Key: D (not having enough money to pay for necessities)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "The money was quickly subscribed and the huge melon brought forth.", what does "subscribed" most nearly mean?

    A. break down, literally or metaphorically

    B. offer to buy, as of stocks and shares

    C. not having enough money to pay for necessities

    D. looking back on the past

    Key: B (offer to buy, as of stocks and shares)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	7, 3, 5, 8, 17, 4, 9, 2, 10, 12, 13, 11, 18, 19, 15, 20	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	5, 7, 10, 4, 3, 1, 8, 2, 12, 13, 11, 18, 15, 14, 21, 16	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	9, 1, 2, 8, 5, 7, 6, 13, 11, 12, 14, 18, 19, 15, 16, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	6, 9, 3, 10, 2, 5, 11, 13, 12, 15, 14, 19, 18, 21, 22, 20	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	3, 8, 2, 4, 23, 11, 13, 12, 15, 18, 14, 19, 16, 21, 20, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	3, 6, 5, 8, 23, 11, 12, 13, 19, 15, 18, 14, 21, 16, 22, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	6, 24, 25, 9, 10, 11, 13, 12, 18, 15, 14, 19, 21, 22, 20, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	5, 9, 24, 10, 17, 13, 12, 11, 19, 15, 14, 18, 16, 21, 20, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	1, 17, 26, 10, 24, 11, 12, 13, 18, 14, 19, 15, 22, 21, 16, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	24, 9, 3, 2, 26, 11, 13, 12, 19, 14, 15, 18, 16, 22, 21, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.4, W.7.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Sweat," how does Hurston show endurance turning to justice? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the symbolism you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): In Sweat, how does Hurston develop the idea of endurance turning to justice? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the symbolism in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Sweat develops the idea of endurance turning to justice. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of Sweat (where it begins, turns and ends) and its symbolism shape the reader's understanding of endurance turning to justice. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what Sweat suggests about endurance turning to justice. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's symbolism and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Zora Neale Hurston uses symbolism in Sweat to complicate the reader's understanding of endurance turning to justice. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Situate Sweat within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of endurance turning to justice responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Read Sweat alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of endurance turning to justice follows or bends those conventions, using the symbolism as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Sweat and its treatment of endurance turning to justice. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's symbolism and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Develop a research argument that reads Sweat as evidence for a larger claim about endurance turning to justice in Sweat. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Develop an original argument that reads Sweat as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of endurance turning to justice. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Sweat.

SAT-style questions

1. *The money was quickly subscribed and the huge melon brought forth.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "subscribed" most nearly mean?

   A. an energetic attempt to achieve something
   B. wear off or die down
   C. offer to buy, as of stocks and shares
   D. pick out, select, or choose from a number of alternatives

2. *It was a hot, hot day near the end of July. The village men on Joe Clarke's porch even chewed cane listlessly. They did not hurl the cane-knots as usual. They let them dribble over the edge of the porch. Even conversation had collapsed under the heat.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Sweat"?

   A. Moral worth found among those society rejects
   B. A family and a house collapsing together
   C. Endurance turning to justice
   D. Accepting one's place in nature's cycle

SAT key: 1. C (offer to buy, as of stocks and shares); 2. C (Endurance turning to justice)

Unit test

Sweat: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Middle School and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is Delia's work?
   A. Farming
   B. Teaching
   C. Washing white people's clothes
   D. Cooking in a hotel

   Key: C (Washing white people's clothes)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Sweat, paragraph 20: “Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with _____ more times than yo' hands is filled it”

   Key: vittles
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “She nearly fell upon the box in her _____, and when she saw what it held, she all but fainted outright.” Word bank: subscribed, penniless, stumbling, retrospection

   Key: stumbling
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Sweat, paragraph 1: “It was eleven o'clock of a Spring night in _____”

   Key: Florida
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is bitten by the snake?
   A. Sykes
   B. A neighbor
   C. Bertha
   D. Delia

   Key: A (Sykes)
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where does Delia wait at the end?
   A. In the barn
   B. Under the Chinaberry tree
   C. In the church
   D. At a neighbor's

Key: B (Under the Chinaberry tree)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whom does Sykes want in the house instead?

   A. His mother

   B. His brother

   C. No one

   D. His mistress, Bertha

   Key: D (His mistress, Bertha)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Sykes use to frighten Delia?

   A. A whip

   B. A gun

   C. A dog

   D. A rattlesnake

   Key: D (A rattlesnake)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Sykes almost let the huge wad of corn bread and collard greens he was _____ fall out of his mouth in amazement." Word bank: subscribed, retrospection, penniless, chewing

   Key: chewing

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Delia descended without fear now, and _____ beneath the low bedroom window." Word bank: retrospection, penniless, crouched, subscribed

    Key: crouched

11. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "The shade torn violently down from the window, letting in the red dawn, a huge brown hand seizing the window stick, great dull blows upon the wooden floor punctuating the gibberish of sound long after the rattle of the snake had abruptly _____."

    Word bank: subscribed, subsided, retrospection, penniless

    Key: subsided

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "Sweat"?

    A. Superstition used against a credulous man

    B. Courage in defense of home

    C. Racial pride destroying love

    D. Endurance turning to justice

    Key: D (Endurance turning to justice)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it" (Sweat, paragraph 20) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Delia's claim.

14. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "Sweat, sweat, sweat! Work and sweat, cry and sweat, pray and sweat" (Sweat, paragraph 18) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Delia.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Sweat”? The snake (and the bullwhip Sykes throws on her, which "looks just like a snake") stands for Sykes's cruelty and, biblically, for evil in the home.

    A. Personification

    B. Conflict

    C. Symbolism

    D. Hyperbole

    Key: C (Symbolism)

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it” (Sweat, paragraph 20).

    Sample answer: She tells him "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it," and sums up fifteen years as "Sweat, sweat, sweat!"; when Sykes's own snake kills him, the story lets her keep what she earned.

17. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Sweat”? Sykes brings the rattlesnake to kill Delia, who fears snakes, and it kills him instead; his weapon recoils on him.

    A. Irony

    B. Conflict

    C. Hyperbole

    D. Foreshadowing

    Key: A (Irony)

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how justice develops from an earlier story to “Sweat”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: Sykes reaps what he sows; the story asks whether Delia's choice not to help is justice, revenge or survival.

19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “It was eleven o'clock of a Spring night in Florida” (Sweat, paragraph 1). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The opening.

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Delia's labor gives her a moral claim to the home that Sykes tries to take.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: She tells him "Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it," and sums up fifteen years as "Sweat, sweat, sweat!"; when Sykes's own snake kills him, the story lets her keep what she earned.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Sweat, sweat, sweat! Work and sweat, cry and sweat, pray and sweat” (Sweat, paragraph 18) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Delia.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Mah tub of suds is filled yo' belly with vittles more times than yo' hands is filled it” (Sweat, paragraph 20) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Delia's claim.

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "She had the memory of his numerous trips to Orlando with all of his wages when he had returned to her penniless, even before the first year had passed.", what does "penniless" most nearly mean?

    A. break down, literally or metaphorically

    B. offer to buy, as of stocks and shares

    C. looking back on the past

    D. not having enough money to pay for necessities

    Key: D (not having enough money to pay for necessities)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "A period of introspection, a space of retrospection, then a mixture of both.", what does "retrospection" most nearly mean?

    A. not having enough money to pay for necessities

    B. looking back on the past

    C. break down, literally or metaphorically

    D. offer to buy, as of stocks and shares

    Key: B (looking back on the past)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "The money was quickly subscribed and the huge melon brought forth.", what does "subscribed" most nearly mean?

    A. break down, literally or metaphorically

    B. offer to buy, as of stocks and shares

    C. not having enough money to pay for necessities

    D. looking back on the past

    Key: B (offer to buy, as of stocks and shares)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Even conversation had collapsed under the heat.", what does "collapsed" most nearly mean?

    A. not having enough money to pay for necessities

    B. break down, literally or metaphorically

    C. looking back on the past

    D. offer to buy, as of stocks and shares

    Key: B (break down, literally or metaphorically)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	8, 5, 11, 4, 2, 7, 10, 9, 1, 6, 3, 13, 12, 14, 19, 17, 15, 20	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	1, 5, 10, 3, 6, 11, 2, 9, 4, 8, 13, 12, 14, 17, 19, 15, 21, 18	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	5, 6, 8, 7, 11, 10, 3, 4, 2, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 19, 17, 22, 18	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	4, 1, 9, 10, 3, 11, 7, 5, 13, 12, 14, 15, 19, 16, 17, 18, 22, 20	

		recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	9, 3, 7, 11, 23, 24, 25, 13, 14, 12, 19, 17, 16, 15, 20, 22, 21, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	10, 4, 6, 2, 11, 9, 25, 12, 14, 13, 16, 15, 17, 19, 22, 21, 18, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	23, 1, 6, 9, 2, 5, 11, 13, 12, 14, 19, 15, 17, 16, 20, 22, 21, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	4, 11, 9, 7, 23, 3, 2, 14, 12, 13, 17, 19, 15, 16, 22, 18, 21, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	5, 9, 10, 1, 6, 4, 3, 14, 12, 13, 15, 16, 17, 19, 21, 18, 20, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	5, 11, 2, 25, 10, 26, 8, 12, 13, 14, 16, 15, 19, 17, 18, 20, 22, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

Sweat: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Zora Neale Hurston develops endurance and justice across Sweat. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in Sweat and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to domestic abuse.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in Sweat. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether Sweat finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of faith. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Middle School 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Endurance and justice

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Sweat teaches about endurance and justice. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Zora Neale Hurston develops endurance and justice in Sweat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Zora Neale Hurston develops endurance and justice across Sweat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Sweat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of endurance and justice. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of endurance and justice in Sweat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Zora Neale Hurston's choices in Sweat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of endurance and justice, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Sweat's treatment of endurance and justice in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on endurance and justice in Sweat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on endurance and justice in Sweat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about endurance and justice in Sweat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on endurance and justice in Sweat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Domestic abuse

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Sweat teaches about domestic abuse. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Zora Neale Hurston develops domestic abuse in Sweat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Zora Neale Hurston develops domestic abuse across Sweat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Sweat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of domestic abuse. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of domestic abuse in Sweat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Zora Neale Hurston's choices in Sweat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of domestic abuse, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Sweat's treatment of domestic abuse in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on domestic abuse in Sweat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on domestic abuse in Sweat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about domestic abuse in Sweat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on domestic abuse in Sweat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Faith

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Sweat teaches about faith. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Zora Neale Hurston develops faith in Sweat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Zora Neale Hurston develops faith across Sweat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Sweat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of faith. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of faith in Sweat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Zora Neale Hurston's choices in Sweat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of faith, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Sweat's treatment of faith in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on faith in Sweat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on faith in Sweat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about faith in Sweat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on faith in Sweat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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